South Tibet). India was concerned by the geopolitical implications of China's Belt and Road Initiative, launched in 2013, and particularly outraged by the inclusion in it of the China Pakistan Economic Corridor, passing through territory in Gilgit Baltistan, which India considers under the illegal occupation of Pakistan (and which, in 1963, China had accepted as territory disputed between India and Pakistan).[15] The prospect of Chinese naval and air bases just off India's coastline on the Arabian Sea was an obvious Indian concern. The Indian government decided not to send any representative to the Belt and Road Forum Summit hosted by President Xi Jinping in May 2017. This rebuff was followed by a tense standoff between Indian and Chinese troops, from June to August that year, on the Doklam plateau near the India–Bhutan–China trijunction, whose precise coordinates remain a matter of dispute. Though an amicable face-saving resolution was found, other irritants persisted in India–China relations. These included Chinese opposition to India's membership of the NSG, blocking the inclusion of a Pakistan-based individual in the UN's list of terrorists, and, at Pakistan's instance, seeking the UN Security Council's intervention on amendments to some Indian constitutional provisions relating to Jammu and Kashmir.

The slide in India–China relations coincided with a relative dip in India–US relations. A range of bilateral issues was responsible for this, but a contributory factor was also India's perception that US–China economic interdependence restrained the Obama administration from going beyond largely symbolic statements and gestures in challenging China's assertive behaviour in its neighbour-hood, its occupation of disputed islands in the South China Sea, and the global ambition signalled by the Belt and Road Initiative (BRI). There has been a sharp change in direction since the advent of the Trump administration in the United States. The